

1. **“Break the ice”**

Meaning: To start a conversation or make people feel more comfortable.

Example: “To break the ice at the party, I said hello to the person next to me.”

2. **“Cut corners”**

Meaning: To do something in the easiest or cheapest way, often badly.

Example: “The company cut corners on safety to save money, which caused problems.”

3. **“Hit the nail on the head”**

Meaning: To describe something exactly right.

Example: “You’ve hit the nail on the head with your idea about the problem.”

4. **“Piece of cake”**

Meaning: Something very easy to do.

Example: “The test was a piece of cake; I finished it very quickly.”

5. **“Cost an arm and a leg”**

Meaning: To be very expensive

Example: “That new phone costs an arm and a leg; I can’t buy it now.”

6. **“Bite off more than you can chew”**

Meaning: To try to do more than you can manage.

Example: “By agreeing to do two big projects at once, I bit off more than I could chew.”

7. **“Beat around the bush”**

Meaning: To avoid talking about what’s important.

Example: “Please stop beating around the bush and tell me what happened.”

8. **“Cry over spilled milk”**

Meaning: To be upset about something that has already happened and can’t be changed.

Example: “Don’t cry over spilled milk; let’s focus on fixing the problem.”

9. **“Get your act together”**

Meaning: To organise yourself and improve your behaviour.

Example: “You need to get your act together if you want to pass this class.”

10. **“Kill two birds with one stone”**

Meaning: To solve two problems with one action.

Example: “By walking to work, I kill two birds with one stone: I save money and get exercise.”

11. **“Let the cat out of the bag”**

Meaning: To reveal a secret by mistake.

Example: “I let the cat out of the bag about the surprise party when I asked her what cake she likes.”

12. **“Pull someone’s leg”**

Meaning: To joke with someone by telling them something that isn’t true.

Example: “Don’t worry, I’m just pulling your leg; I didn’t really sell your bike.”

13. **“Burn the midnight oil”**

Meaning: To work late into the night.

Example: “I’ve been burning the midnight oil to finish this project before the deadline.”

14. **“Bite the bullet”**

Meaning: To do something difficult or unpleasant that you have been avoiding.

Example: “I finally bit the bullet and went to the dentist after waiting for months.”

15. **“Break a leg”**

Meaning: A way of wishing someone good luck, especially before a performance.

Example: “You’re going to do great in the play tonight. Break a leg!”

16. **“Call it a day”**

Meaning: To stop working on something.

Example: “We’ve done a lot of work on the report. Let’s call it a day and continue tomorrow.”

17. **“Steal someone’s thunder”**

Meaning: To take attention away from someone else’s achievement.

Example: “I was about to share my good news, but my sister stole my thunder by announcing her engagement.”

18. **“The ball is in your court”**

Meaning: It’s your turn to take action or make a decision.

Example: “I’ve made my offer; now the ball is in your court to decide.”

19. **“Throw in the towel”**

Meaning: To give up.

Example: “After trying for hours to fix the computer, I threw in the towel and called an expert.”

20. **“Under the weather”**

Meaning: Feeling slightly ill.

Example: “I’m feeling a bit under the weather today; I might stay home and rest.”

21. **“Speak of the devil”**

Meaning: Said when someone appears just as you’re talking about them.

Example: “Speak of the devil! We were just talking about you when you walked in.”

22. **“Once in a blue moon”**

Meaning: Very rarely.

Example: “I only eat fast food once in a blue moon; I usually cook at home.”

23. **“Catch someone red-handed”**

Meaning: To catch someone while they are doing something wrong.

Example: “The teacher caught the student red-handed trying to cheat on the test.

24. **“Barking up the wrong tree”**

Meaning: To look for something in the wrong place or to blame the wrong person.

Example: “If you think I took your book, you’re barking up the wrong tree. I haven’t seen it.”

25. **“Jump on the bandwagon”**

Meaning: To join an activity that has become popular.

Example: “When healthy eating became popular, many people jumped on the bandwagon.”

26. **“Like two peas in a pod”**

Meaning: Very similar or close.

Example: “Those best friends are like two peas in a pod; they do everything together.”

27. **“Ten a penny”**

Meaning: Very common and not special or valuable.

Example: “Empty promises are ten a penny; I need to see real actions.”

28. **“Go the extra mile”**

Meaning: To make an extra effort.

Example: “Our teachers always go the extra mile to help students understand difficult topics.”

29. **“Straight from the horse’s mouth”**

Meaning: Information from the person who knows best.

Example: “I heard about the university’s new policy straight from the horse’s mouth – the vice-chancellor told us herself.”

30. **“Take with a pinch of salt”**

Meaning: To not completely believe something.

Example: “You should take his stories with a pinch of salt; he often exaggerates.”

31. **“To feel like a million bucks”**

Meaning: To feel wonderful or in great health.

Example: “I feel like a million bucks after that workout!”

32. **“Miss the boat”**

Meaning: To miss an opportunity.

Example: “Don’t miss the boat on this great deal.”

33. **“A dime a dozen”**

Meaning: Something very common and not special.

Example: “Those shoes are a dime a dozen.”

34. **“To be in the red/black”**

Meaning: To be losing money (to be in the negative).

Example: “My stocks aren’t doing well right now; they’re in the red.”

35. **“The elephant in the room”**

Meaning: A problem that everyone is avoiding discussing.

Example: “Let’s address the elephant in the room.”

36. **“Break the bank”**

Meaning: Very expensive, to spend more than someone can afford.

Example: “I can’t buy this car, it’ll break the bank.”

37. **“By the skin of your/my teeth”**

Meaning: To narrowly escape something or barely achieve something.

Example: “You passed that course by the skin of your teeth”.

38. **“Hit the sack/hay”**

Meaning: Go to sleep

Example: “I’m exhausted; I’m going to hit the hay.”

39. **“On the ball”**

Meaning: Doing a good job, being on top of it

Example: “Thanks for the reminder – you’re on the ball!”

40. **“The last straw:**

Meaning: Patience has run out

Example: “You’re always late; this is the last straw.”

41. **“To make matters worse”**

Meaning: To make the problem worse

Example: “To make matters worse, it started raining!”

42. **“Don’t count your chickens before they hatch”**

Meaning: Don’t count on something good to happen until it’s actually happened

Expression: “Although the interview went well, don’t count your chickens before they hatch – wait for the offer letter.”

43. **“Comparing apples to oranges”**

Meaning: Comparing two things that are too different and cannot be compared

Example: “Comparing Italian food with Mexican food is like comparing apples to oranges.”

44. **“The whole nine yards”**

Meaning: Everything, to go all the way

Example: “She went the whole nine yards to celebrate my birthday!”

45. **“A storm in a teacup”**

Meaning: A big fuss about a small problem

Example: “It’s just a little traffic; you’re making it a storm in a teacup.”

46. **“Cut [somebody] some slack”**

Meaning: Don’t be so critical

Example: “I tried my best; cut me some slack.”

47. **“It’s not rocket science”**

Meaning: It’s not difficult or complicated

Example: “You just need to restart your laptop; it’s not rocket science.”

48. **“You can say that again”**

Meaning: That’s true, I agree

Example: “It’s so hot today.” “You can say that again!”

49. **“Bent out of shape”**

Meaning: To get upset about something

Example: “They got bent out of shape because they missed the bus.”

50. **“A picture is worth a thousand words”**

Meaning: It’s better to show it than to talk about it

Example: “Looking at their wedding photo, you can tell they’re so happy – a picture is worth a thousand words.”